DECLINE AND FALL OF AZAM KHAN

FOR THE FIRST TIME IN FOUR DECADES, RAMPUR AND SP STRONGMAN AZAM KHAN FINDS HIMSELF DISQUALIFIED AND WITHOUT A SEAT IN THE HOUSE. THE YOGI REGIME IS NOW HOT ON HIS TRAIL

By Ashish Misra



LONELY ROAD AHEAD
Azam Khan (centre) with son Abdullah Azam and supporters in Rampur

Azam Khan was unusually quiet as he and his supporters waited at the MP-MLA court complex in Moradabad on February 13. The usually belligerent general secretary of the Samajwadi Party (SP) was waiting for a verdict on a case from way back in 2008, when he and his supporters had created a ruckus at the Chhajlet police station in Moradabad district. On New Year's Day in 2008, there had been a terrorist attack on the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) camp in Rampur (incidentally Azam's home district) after which a high alert had been declared in the whole state. The next day, Azam's convoy was on its way to a marriage when it was stopped for vehicle checks in Chhajlet. An enraged Azam and his supporters ended up blocking the highway for several hours. The police had then registered a case against nine people, including Azam and his younger son Abdullah Azam.

It was almost 6 pm when additional chief judicial magistrate Smita Goswami pronounced her verdict—Azam and Abdullah were sentenced to two years' jail for obstructing government work. It was just the latest in a series of reverses for the Rampur strongman (Azam is a 10-time MLA from here) and one of the founders of the Samajwadi Party. The mood in the Mirbaz Khan locality adjacent to the district jail in Rampur was telling. Till recently, the streets used to be full of supporters whenever Azam was at home. Indeed, he had the status of a "mini chief minister" in the previous SP government (2012-17). Today, the streets are deserted and Azam's house, once guarded by at least a dozen armed security personnel, has just a lone guard sitting outside. After the Moradabad court verdict, Azam has gone incommunicado. Although family members cite ill health, Abdul Haleem, Rampur resident and former professor of sociology at the Mahatma Jyotiba Phule Rokilhand University, says, "Azam always had a big mouth, but he got away with it because he was the firebrand 'Muslim face' of the SP. Now, his reckless attitude has come back to bite him."

In the past four months, Azam has been handed two jail terms. Earlier, on October 27, 2022, the Rampur MP-MLA court had sentenced him to three years imprisonment for making inflammatory speeches. This led to